personalities.[22] This gallery includes kings with their consorts, most often rulers of the Satavahana dynasty who happened to be the chief patrons of Kanaganahalli at this point in time.[23] Each appears with an epigraphic label designating them ‘Raya Matalako’, ‘Raya Sundara Satakarni’, and so on. It is at Ashoka, or ‘Raya Asoko’ as he is described here, that we need to pause.

There are two panels whose subject matter is Ashoka, with label inscriptions identifying him by name. One of these is like the Satavahana portraits. By this I mean that, unlike Sanchi, Ashoka does not feature on the panel as part of a narrative scene. Instead, his queen and he dominate the register. Apart from the queen, there are female ‘chauri’ bearers and a female umbrella bearer.[24] The royal couple seems to be sharing a tender moment: Ashoka’s face is turned towards his queen while she looks at him with adoration. The subject matter of the second panel’s lower register, also bearing the five-lettered label ‘Raya Asoko’, is qualitatively different from the portrait depiction. Ashoka stands to the left of the Bodhi tree with several others who are shown worshipping in a similar way. The excavator of Kanaganahalli believed one of these was Prince Mahinda and the woman behind the king his daughter Sanghamitra.[25] Whether this was so or not, the frieze is a powerful reminder that in the imagination of ancient India the presence of the emperor was frequently evoked in relation to Mahabodhi, snapshots of which can be seen all the way from Bharhut to Kanaganahalli.

The strength of this association—between the place where the Buddha attained enlightenment and where India’s Buddhist emperor built a shrine in his memory—is evident from its spread beyond the territories over which Ashoka had ruled. Bodh Gaya was an exceptionally important place for pilgrims and patrons from Myanmar.[26] The historian Upinder Singh points out that the importance attached to the Mahabodhi temple is manifest in Myanmar from epigraphs, as also from its representation in the form of temple models, and depictions on seals and plaques. The inscriptions which